

School-Day Routines

Built on the BRIDGE Method — so the whole family uses the same steady, practical approach to the moments that tend to go sideways: getting out the door, and winding back down again.



These routines put **D — Design Matching Strategies** into practice: everyday steps simple enough to actually stick, at home, on a real weekday morning.

Early Years (3–5)

Short steps, said out loud, in the same order every day. At this age the routine works better as a rhythm you narrate than a list they read.

BRIDGE tip — G: Give Consistent Language

When a transition is the hard part, name the feeling first, then offer a choice: *"You don't want to stop playing — that's hard. Do you want to walk to the car like a bunny hop or a robot?"* The same two phrases, used every day, become a script your child can predict.

● Morning

- ☐ 6:30 Wake up, get dressed (with help)
- ☐ 6:45 Eat breakfast together
- ☐ 7:05 Brush teeth and hair
- ☐ 7:15 Shoes, bag, and coat by the door
- ☐ 7:25 Quick cuddle, then goodbye

● After School

- ☐ 3:30 Big hug and a snack
- ☐ 3:45 Free play or quiet time
- ☐ 5:30 Dinner as a family
- ☐ 6:30 Bath, pajamas, story
- ☐ 7:00 Lights out

What helps at this age: a visual chart with pictures instead of words, the same 2–3 songs or phrases to signal each step, and a five-minute warning before transitions.

Primary (6–10)

Kids this age can own a checklist. Let them tick their own boxes — it builds independence and cuts down on morning nagging.

BRIDGE tip – B: Behavior has a Reason

If mornings or homework keep stalling, pause before reacting. Ask: is this *escape* (the task feels too hard), *attention*, or a *skill gap* — not just defiance? A two-minute check before responding changes what you do next.

● Morning

- ☐ 6:45 Wake up, get dressed, make bed
- ☐ 7:00 Breakfast
- ☐ 7:20 Brush teeth, pack bag, check homework folder
- ☐ 7:35 Shoes and coat on
- ☐ 7:45 Out the door

● After School

- ☐ 3:30 Snack and decompress — no questions yet
- ☐ 3:45 Outside or free play
- ☐ 4:15 Homework or reading block
- ☐ 4:45 Free choice activity
- ☐ 6:00 Dinner as a family
- ☐ 6:30 Pack bag for tomorrow
- ☐ 7:30 Shower, read, lights out

What helps at this age: a checklist taped inside a cupboard or on their door, letting natural consequences do some teaching (forgotten homework folder = a note to the teacher, not a rescue mission), and a fixed homework time before screens.

Tweens & Teens (11+)

The goal shifts from "follow steps" to "manage themselves." Set the outer boundaries — wake time, homework block, screens-off time — and let them fill in the order.

BRIDGE tip – G: Give Consistent Language

If evenings get tense, the goal isn't to win the moment — it's to keep tomorrow's routine intact. A steady line to fall back on: *"I'm not going to argue about this right now. Let's figure it out at [set time]."* That's as much for your own regulation as theirs.

● Morning

- ☐ 6:30 Own alarm, own wake-up
- ☐ 6:30 Shower and get dressed
- ☐ 6:50 Breakfast
- ☐ 7:10 Check bag, planner, and that devices are charged
- ☐ 7:25 Leave

● After School

- ☐ 3:30 Decompress: snack, music, downtime
- ☐ 4:00 Sport, clubs, or activities (varies by day)
- ☐ 5:00 Homework block
- ☐ 6:30 Dinner and family time
- ☐ 7:15 Free time, within agreed screen limits
- ☐ 9:00 Devices away, start winding down
- ☐ 9:30 Lights out

What helps at this age: agreeing the boundaries together rather than dictating them, a shared family charging station for devices overnight, and treating one missed deadline as a conversation, not a crisis.

Whole Family, Synced

When you've got kids in more than one age band, the routines above run in parallel. Use this to see where everyone lines up — like dinner — and where each child is doing their own thing.

BRIDGE tip – R + I: Record the Pattern, Identify One Shared Goal

This synced view is those two steps in practice. If mornings feel chaotic, don't try to fix everything at once — pick one shared target everyone's working toward, like "out the door by 7:30," and track just that for a week before adding another.

Morning

Time	Early Years	Primary	Tweens & Teens
6:30	Wake, dress (with help)	–	Alarm, shower
6:45	Breakfast	Wake, dress, make bed	–
7:00	–	Breakfast	Breakfast
7:05	Teeth & hair	–	–
7:10	–	–	Check bag & planner
7:15	Shoes, bag, coat	–	–
7:20	–	Teeth, pack bag	–
7:25	Goodbye hug	–	Leave
7:35–7:45	–	Shoes, coat, out the door	–

After School & Evening

Time	Early Years	Primary	Tweens & Teens
3:30	Hug & snack	Snack, decompress	Decompress
3:45–4:00	Free play	Outside play	Clubs / sport
4:15	–	Homework	–
4:45	–	Free choice	–
5:00	–	–	Homework block
5:30	Dinner	–	–
6:00	–	Dinner	–

Time	Early Years	Primary	Tweens & Teens
6:30	Bath, pajamas	Pack bag for tomorrow	Dinner & family time
7:00–7:15	Story, bedtime	–	Free time (screens)
7:30	Asleep	Shower, read, lights out	–
9:00–9:30	–	–	Wind down, lights out

The trick with mixed ages: anchor everyone around one or two shared moments (dinner works well) and let each child's individual steps happen either side of it, rather than trying to run everyone on one identical timetable. Then bring it back to the family at a regular check-in — **E: Evaluate & Adjust Together** — to see what's working before you change anything.

MettleNest exists to make behavior support practical, respectful, and within reach. These routines are one small piece of the BRIDGE Method, the same shared framework taught to parents and educators so a child gets consistent support at home and at school.

Connection · Collaboration · Communication